Taming Your Thoughts: How Your Mind Shapes Your Anxiety

Autumn Persinger, PMHNP-BC

Hi, I'm Autumn Persinger. I'm a psychiatric nurse practitioner at Real Psychiatric Services, and I'll be your guide for this next part of your journey.

First, I want to acknowledge the incredible work you did in Part 1. Understanding that anxiety is your body's alarm system—and learning you have a "brake pedal"—is a massive step forward.

Now, we'll turn our attention inward. Have you ever noticed how a single worried thought can send your heart racing? That's the powerful connection between our minds and our bodies. The physical feelings of anxiety are often triggered and fueled by our thought patterns.

My core philosophy is simple: **Your care is in your hands.** While your thoughts can feel automatic, you have the power to change your *response* to them. You can learn to see them, challenge them gently, and reduce their power over you.

In this part of the course, we're going to explore practical, evidence-based tools to do exactly that. Let's get started.

Building on Your Foundation

Part One

Understanding your body's alarm system

Learning physical calming techniques

Part Two

Identifying thought patterns

Recognizing thinking traps

The Goal

Developing balanced thinking

Creating lasting cognitive skills

The Runaway Thought Train

One worry appears

A single concern enters your mind

Thoughts connect

That worry links to several others

Overwhelm follows

You feel exhausted and anxious

This pattern is completely normal. You're not choosing these thoughts. They happen automatically.

What Drives Your Anxiety?

The Thought

"I'm going to mess up this presentation."

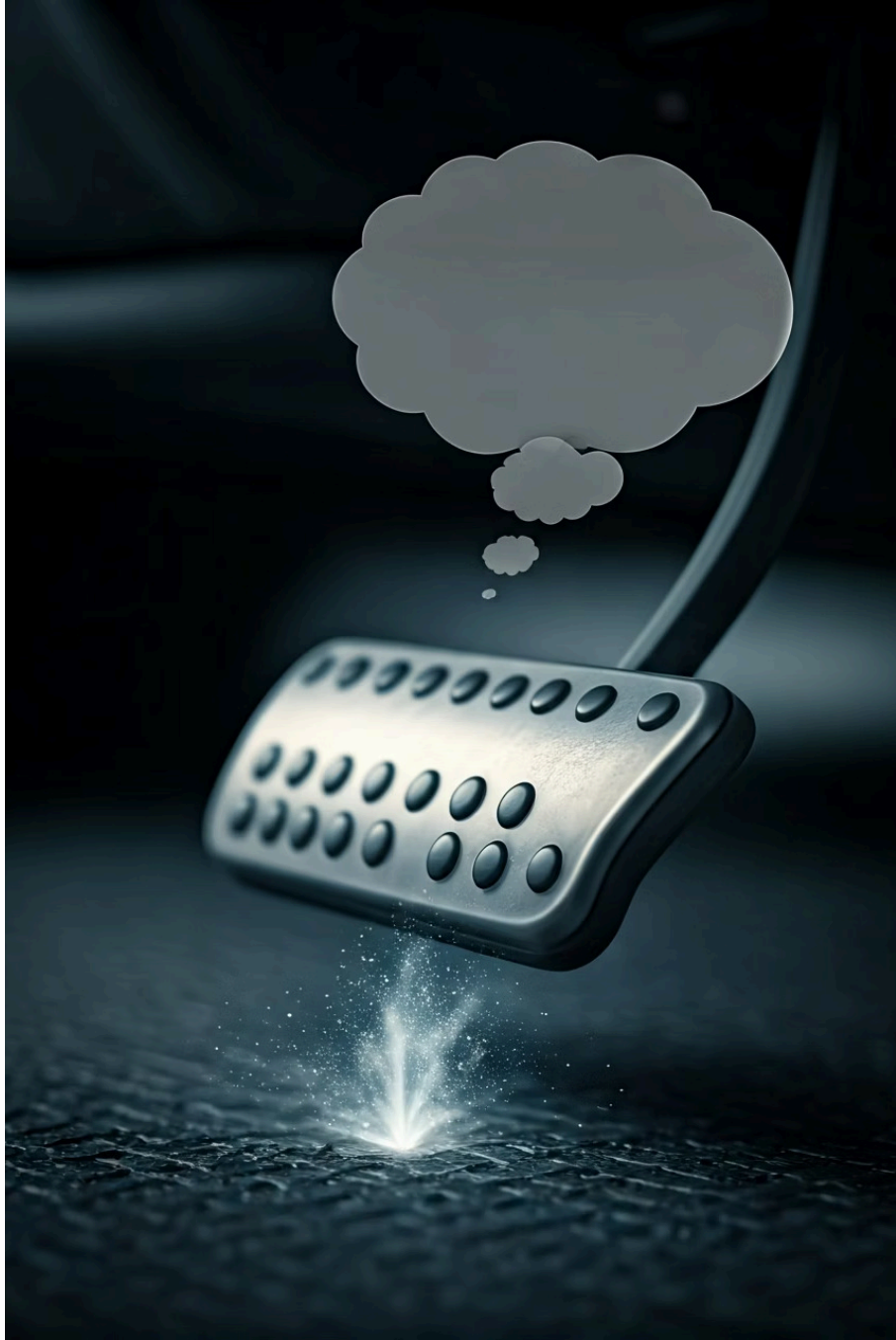
The Feeling

Anxiety, dread, knot in your stomach

The Action

Procrastinating, over-preparing, avoiding

One thought can trigger your entire anxiety response. This connection is powerful but can be managed.



Becoming a Thought Detective

Catastrophizing

Assuming the worst possible outcome

"This headache must be a brain tumor."

Mind Reading

Believing you know what others think

"Everyone at the party thinks I'm boring."

Black and White Thinking

Seeing situations as all good or all bad

"If I make one mistake, I'm a total failure."

These common thinking traps fuel anxiety. Learning to spot them is your first step toward freedom.

The Power of Balanced Thinking

Anxious Thought

"I'll never get through this presentation without panicking."

- Assumes certainty
- Offers no hope
- Feels overwhelming

Balanced Thought

"Presentations make me nervous, but I've managed difficult things before."

- Acknowledges feelings
- Recalls past strengths
- Opens possibilities

We don't aim for forced positivity. We seek what's realistic and true.

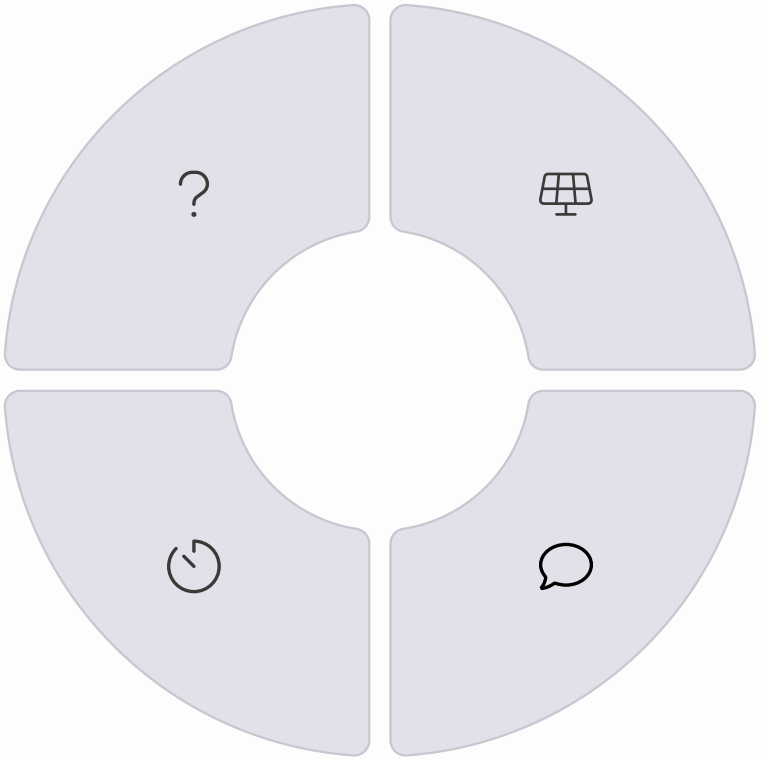
Your Thought-Balancing Toolkit

Evidence Check

What facts support or contradict this thought?

Compassionate Friend

What would you tell a friend with this worry?



Time Travel

Will this matter in a week? A month? A year?

Perspective Shift

How might someone else view this situation?

These simple techniques help challenge anxious thoughts gently and effectively.

Your Journey Continues

Notice Your Patterns

Begin observing your thoughts without judgment. Simply notice when anxiety patterns emerge.

Practice Gentle Questioning

Apply your toolkit to challenge anxious thoughts. Start with small worries first.

Celebrate Your Progress

Each time you notice a thought trap is a victory. Growth takes time and practice.

Remember: Your care is in your hands. I'm simply your guide. You are absolutely capable of learning these skills.

More about Autumn Persinger

About Autumn Persinger, PMHNP-BC

Autumn Persinger brings a wealth of diverse experience and a uniquely holistic perspective to her practice. With a nursing background spanning critical care, emergency medicine, and inpatient psychiatry, she is skilled at maintaining calm and creating safety, even in high-stress situations. Her specialized training as a sexual assault nurse examiner has deepened her trauma-informed approach, ensuring every patient feels respected and heard.

Autumn is passionate about functional psychiatry, exploring how nutritional imbalances and lifestyle habits can influence mental health. She believes in a patient-centered model where her role is to educate and guide, empowering you to make informed decisions about your well-being.

> *"Your care is in your hands. I'm here to educate, guide, and offer options—medical or holistic—that truly align with your goals."*

Clients consistently praise Autumn for her gentle, non-pushy, and nurturing approach. As one patient shared, "She provides a very safe, nurturing environment to open up and discuss whatever I felt I needed to… she never once judged me for them or made me feel uncomfortable."

For more about Autumn's background, philosophy, and the full provider team, visit:
realpsychiatricservices.com/meet-your-providers